

how it threatens the way we compute. Our perspectives are clouded by the 'coolness' or 'utilitarian' value of our choices. Or how much 'convenience' they provide in some area of our lives. At least ten years back, the situation was not so bad because we didn't have the cloud, we didn't have smart gadgets and we didn't have various smartphone application repositories. Free software presented us with the only paradigm whereby we could take complete control and ownership of the technology that affected our lives and work.

The cloud enables us to use proprietary software that runs on someone else's computer. Smart gadgets are nothing but hardware + software combinations with the software providing the ability to track us. Smartphone applications are another way proprietary software creeps into the daily life of even the most ardent free software user. Finally, there is proprietary JavaScript that runs in our browsers which is a silent threat to our computing freedom.

The reason I say that the current status of FOSS is below (my) expectations is because when you observe the amount of proprietary software that we use today, it is actually far more than what we used even ten or 15 years back. And for some reason that doesn't bother us as much.

While FOSS has enabled the creation of so much wealth and software, and while it is impossible today to do anything that is not derived from or based on FOSS, we still use much less of it.

We might not be able to remove proprietary software from our lives completely. But by being mindful, by building and then following an identifiable free software value system, and by reminding ourselves of what really matters to us, we can limit this usage (and its impact) to the minimum.

Q How do you see FOSS evolving from here?

Free software is going to be even more

important in the future. As we race to protect our privacy, and to safeguard our freedom to study, learn, extend, fix, modify, share, embed and host software, we will discover that we can't do all of these things without also caring about free software.

In the future, we might have to focus a lot more on doing our own computing and building our own technology. As self-hosting becomes the norm and as DIY becomes a 'default choice' for some people, free software should become more relevant, important and indispensable.

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Unless we carefully choose the hardware we purchase, we will slowly run out of places to run our software on. So many products today are combinations of hardware and software. However, very few of them provide us the freedom we deserve. The future of free software, in general, is also dependent upon our ability to run free software everywhere we want to. And to do that, we need to either choose our hardware carefully or design hardware in a manner that it can provide this very important freedom to its users.

Q What is the role of India (and Indians) with respect to FOSS?

Since India (and Indians) are the biggest consumers of software across all devices and computing systems,

we can choose to have the most (or least) impactful role with respect to FOSS.

There are a few aspects where FOSS is even more relevant to India.

If we want to create a level playing field for everyone to build software and hardware and if we want to see some sort of 'equality', then there is nothing better than free software to achieve this.

Using and promoting free software is a way to create equal opportunities for everyone - irrespective of their technical, social or economic background.

If we can build, service, extend, share and maintain our own software and hardware, software freedom can lead to self-reliance. Software freedom provides us with an opportunity to learn and build skills and competency. It is up to us to use this opportunity to create a culture of self-reliance. If we don't do that (i.e., if we are just consumers of FOSS), then we are not even drawing the benefits from the (technological) freedom that we have.

There are problems, constraints and opportunities that are uniquely Indian in nature. If we choose to solve these problems by using and building free software + libre hardware, then that can help us to really own the solution that we build. That solution will not be the domain or property of a single person or company - it will be the users and community that can really own it and draw benefits from it.

We can't expect someone from outside India to understand or appreciate these problems enough to localise the solutions for them. And in that respect, there is no better way than to use and build free software.

In a nutshell, it is up to all of us to make the best use of the opportunity that free software provides us to solve our problems ethically and elegantly. That is how we can play a significant role in the global free software ecosystem as well.